

SANJEEV SHUKLA, 54

A SUDDEN LOSS: When the pandemic hit, Shukla was earning about Rs 1 crore a year at Muthoot Finance. After having lost his job in the early months, he says he has found it impossible to find equivalent employment elsewhere.

"THE LOSS OF A JOB IS A LOSS OF FACE, POSITION AND STATUS. THE ACCOMPANYING EMOTIONAL TRAUMA IS MUCH BIGGER THAN ONE IMAGINES"

from Delhi, a 54-year-old marketing professional with a 30-year corporate career who was earning a crore per year as chief marketing officer at Muthoot Finance when the pandemic hit. Like many others, Shukla found himself without a job in 2020. While he remains much better off than others who lost their jobs (his wife remains employed, the family has 30 years of savings, assets and so on) Shukla's lifestyle received a major jolt, forcing his family to sell their cars and dramatically reduce consumption. He now worries about the education of his children, who are in expensive universities, and about a lack of funds for medical emergencies and old age. And if he was looking for succour in Budget 2022, he was disappointed. "We were expecting some changes in the income tax slabs—it would have helped," he says.

Though Sitharaman acknowledged the contribution of the middle class to India's economic growth in her budget speech, her budget itself had little for them by way of hope. Like Yatin Bharadwaj, 26, who set up a gym in Delhi in January 2020, only to have the Covid lockdown that followed soon after stymie his ambition. He endured months without any income and now makes just Rs 15,000 a month—half as